

SHOULD THE LEFT NAV BECOME CONTEXTUAL?

Account → Event → Session.

The app already swaps the sidebar when you move from account to event. A deep session is simply the next context down — so the left rail *should* become a session rail. That isn't "nav inside nav"; it's the same level-change the product already makes. The whole bet rides on **orientation**, and that's where Model 2 has to earn it.

3

nav levels

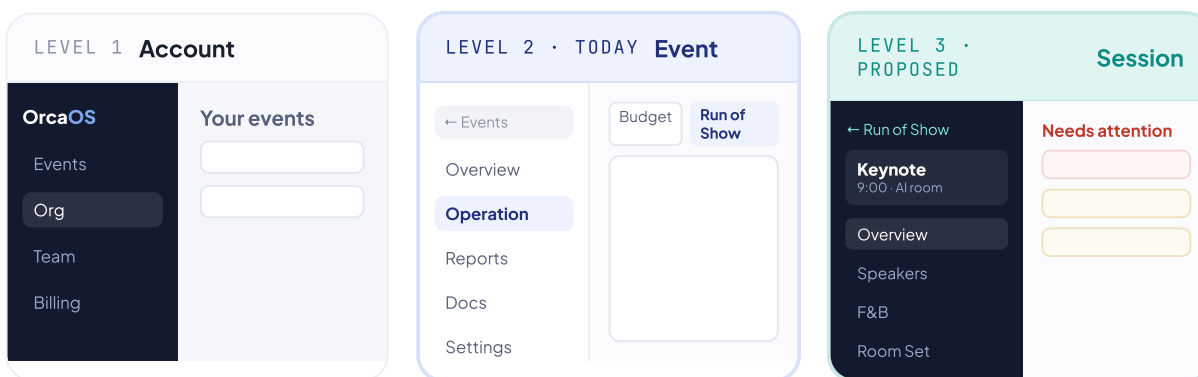
2

models compared

01

The sidebar already changes by context

so a session rail is a continuation, not a contradiction



INSIGHT

The previous concept felt like "nav inside nav" because it added a session rail *beside* the event rail. Replace rather than stack: entering a session swaps the sidebar, exactly like entering an event already does.

02

The two models, side by side

same session, two nav strategies

Both show the Keynote session. The difference is entirely in the chrome — what the left rail does, and how many navigation systems are on screen at once.

1

Keep global nav + in-page tabs

3 nav systems

OrcaOS

Annual Sales...
Feb 26 - Apr 2

Overview

Operation

Reports

Docs

Activity

Settings

Budget

Run of Show

Timeline

Staffing

Speakers

nav B

← Back to Run of Show

Overview

F&B

AV

Staffing

...

nav C

Keynote

nav A

2

Contextual session rail

1 nav system

← Back to Run of Show

ANNUAL SALES CONF

Keynote

9:00-10:00 · AI room

MODULES

Overview

Speakers

AV

F&B

Staffing

Room Set

Seating

Conflicts

Notes

one rail

Run of Show / Feb 26 / Keynote

Session mode

Save

Needs your attention · 4

Session at a glance

- + Zero relearning — the shell never moves.

+ Event nav is one click away at all times.

- Three competing nav systems on one screen (rail, top tabs, module tabs).

- Modules crammed into a horizontal strip — 8 won't fit; status gets truncated.

- The session never feels like its own place. It reads as a sub-page.
- + One nav system. The session owns the screen.

+ All 8 modules fit vertically, each carrying live readiness.

+ The is the readiness ledger — nav and status rail are the same object.

+ Matches the muscle memory of the account→event swap.

~ Costs the event nav its always-visible slot — so the escape hatch must be loud.

03

Scored against what matters

CRITERION	Model 1 · global + tabs	Model 2 · session rail
Natural for operators	Familiar, but a session feels like a tabbed sub-page.	Wins. Mirrors the account→event swap they already do.

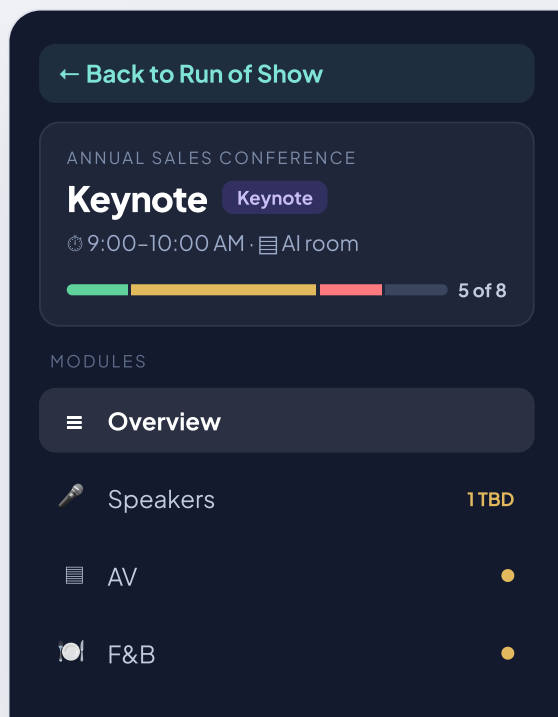
Less clutter	Three nav systems stacked; modules truncated in a strip.	Wins. One rail; all 8 modules breathe vertically.
Feels powerful	Reads as a settings form bolted under the event.	Wins. A dedicated mode signals “this is real work.”
Wayfinding safety	Edge. Event nav never disappears.	Safe <i>only with</i> strong orientation + a loud escape hatch (next section).
Deep-linking	Lands on a tab; surrounding chrome is generic.	Wins. Rail opens with that module active & highlighted.
Getting back to RoS	“Back” link + the event tab still sitting there.	Pinned “← Back to Run of Show” at the rail’s top — always one click.

VERDICT **Model 2 — the contextual session rail.** It wins on naturalness, clutter, power and deep-linking. Its one risk is wayfinding, and that’s fully solvable with orientation. Model 1’s only real advantage is that it’s safe by doing nothing.

04 • RECOMMENDED

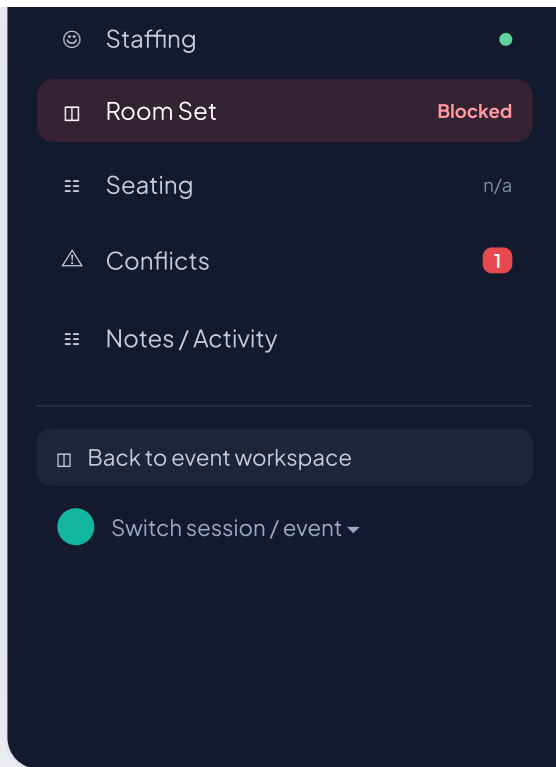
Session mode, oriented so you never feel lost

The rail earns the swap by over-investing in orientation: event name, breadcrumb, a pinned way back, and the live session identity — all before the module list. The bottom holds the escape hatch so leaving is as obvious as arriving.



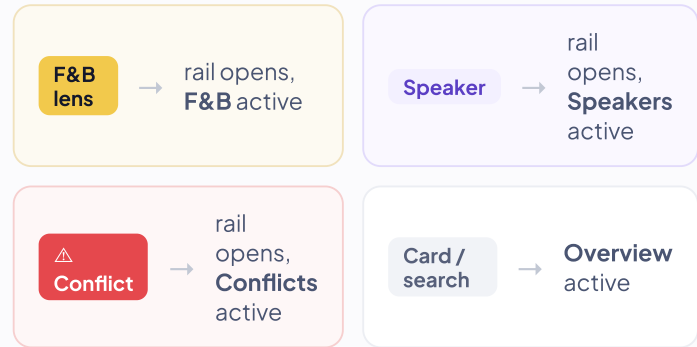
ORIENTATION ANATOMY — TOP TO BOTTOM

- 1 A pinned way back, first**
“← Back to Run of Show” sits at the very top in accent teal — the single most important affordance, never scrolled away.
- 2 Identity card answers “where am I?”**
Event name, session title, type, time, room — plus the honest readiness meter. You always know the session and its overall state.
- 3 Modules = nav and ledger in one**
Each item navigates *and* reports status. No separate readiness panel; the thing you click is the thing that tells you what’s wrong.
- 4 A loud escape hatch at the bottom**



“Back to event workspace” restores the event nav; the switcher hops sessions or events without going all the way out. Leaving is never a guess.

DEEP-LINK BEHAVIOR — THE RAIL OPENS PRE-FOCUSED



However you arrive, the breadcrumb and identity card are identical — only the highlighted module differs. Context is preserved, never reset.

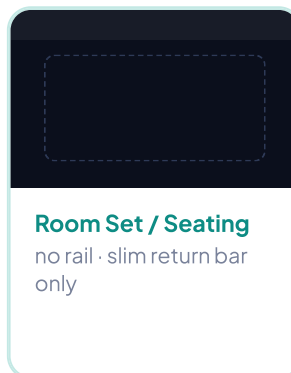
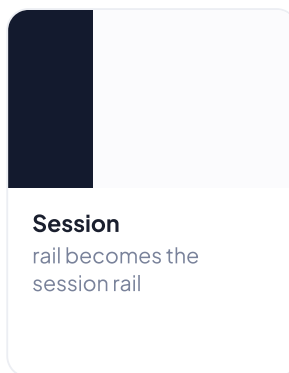
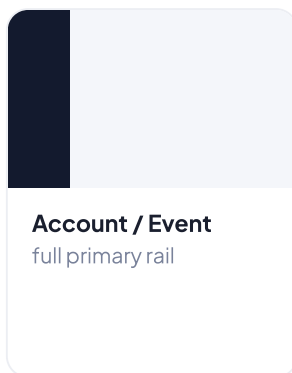
05

Room Set & Seating shed the rail entirely

a fourth level — chrome falls away as you go deeper

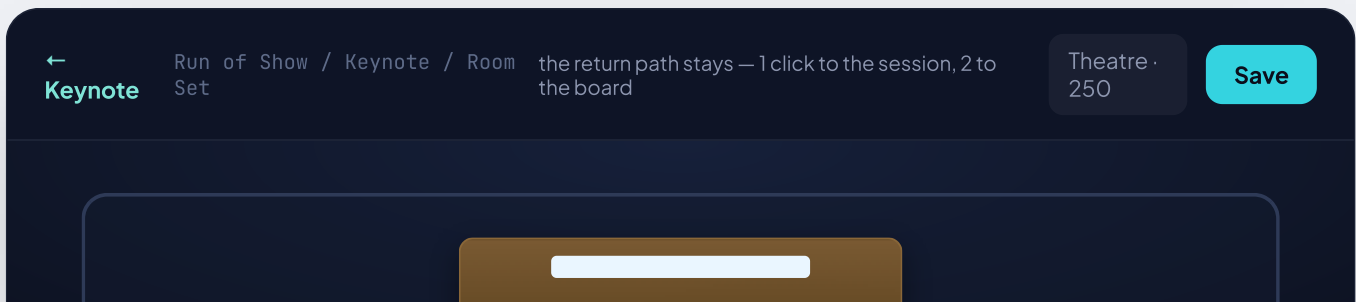
The session rail is right for orchestration, wrong for an immersive canvas. Room Set and Seating are **not** modules that inherit the rail — they open as their own focused workspace where the floor plan owns the full width. The pattern is consistent: each level down sheds a layer of chrome, and a slim return bar keeps the path home short.

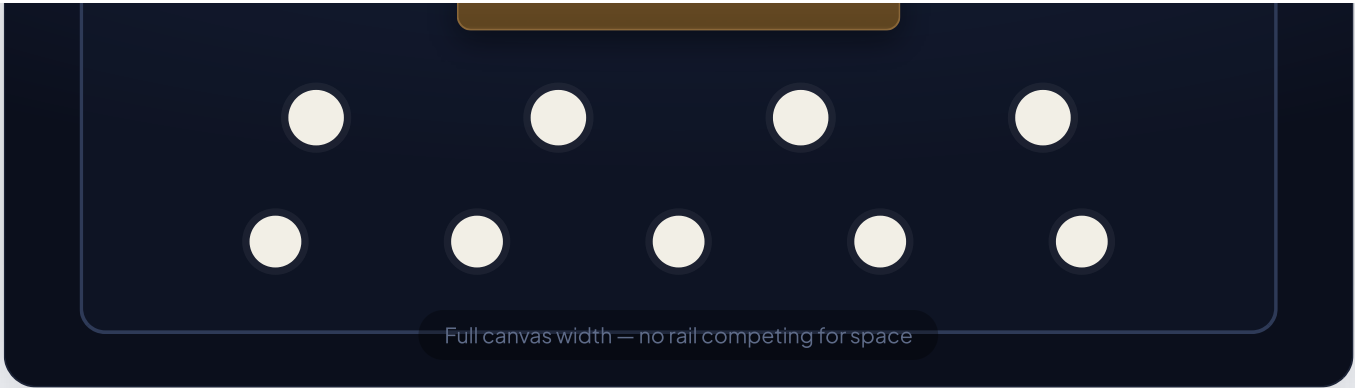
PROGRESSIVE CHROME — FULL RAIL → SESSION RAIL → BARE CANVAS



Why shed it?

A layout editor needs every pixel. Carrying the rail would shrink the canvas and mix two interaction models — orchestration vs. direct manipulation.





REC Ship the contextual session rail

MODEL

Entering a session **swaps** the left rail into a session rail — the same level-change as account→event. Never stacked beside it.

ORIENTATION

Pinned back-link, identity card, breadcrumb, and a bottom **escape hatch**. Wayfinding is the price of the swap — pay it loudly.

RAIL = LEDGER

Module nav and readiness are **one object**. Deep links open the rail pre-focused on the module you came for.

EDITORS

Room Set & Seating **shed the rail** for a full canvas, keeping only a slim return bar — a clean 4th level.

HIERARCHY

Account rail



Event rail



Session rail



Bare-canvas editor

— one rail at a time, always a way back.